

Origins of the World Wars

Instructor: Alexander Trubowitz

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Overview: This course introduces advanced undergraduate students to social-scientific and historical debates about the causes of the First and Second World Wars. Students will learn to connect theory with historical evidence and to evaluate competing explanations. Traditional and revisionist accounts of the origins of these conflicts will be assessed against one another. To what extent was the outbreak of the First World War Britain's fault? Were authoritarian regimes or democracies more resistant to an early negotiated end to the First World War? How different were Hitler's foreign policy goals from those of his predecessors in Weimar Germany? Was appeasement a rational strategy in the 1930s, and was there a diplomatic settlement that could have averted war in 1939? Was the Holocaust the implementation of a preexisting Nazi objective, or did it emerge through the cumulative radicalization of Nazi policy during the war? These and other questions will be discussed. Due to time limitations, this course focuses on the European dimension of the World Wars. Students will leave the course with a command of international relations theory on the causes of war and with a deeper understanding of the origins of the greatest catastrophes in modern European history.

Requirements:

Weekly reading: Students are expected to complete the week's readings before the first lecture of the week. The assigned material amounts to 80–100 pages per week, involving excerpts from longer scholarly works.

In-class midterm (Week 7): multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 30% of course grade.

In-class final exam: multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 30% of course grade.

Book review (Week 8): Students will pick one of the historical texts in the first five weeks of the syllabus to read in full (Tuchman, Steiner and Wilson, McMeekin, Clark, or Ferguson). Reconstruct the author's causal argument in detail and assess its explanatory power in light of the theories, evidence, and alternative interpretations covered in the course. 6-8 pages, double spaced. 25% of your grade, based on the written review and a meeting with me following the submission of the review. More detailed guidelines circulated separately.

Participation: active participation in class on the basis of careful engagement with the readings is expected and is worth 15% of your course grade. In this course, we will uphold the university's code of conduct and values regarding open intellectual inquiry and equal respect for all class members.

Prerequisites: Introduction to International Relations or approved equivalent.

Electronic devices: Laptops are permitted for note-taking and for referring to course readings. Please be conscious of the fact that browsing the internet during class is distracting for the students sitting around you. If you plan to browse the internet during class time, expect to be called upon!

Plagiarism: Plagiarism is a serious breach of the University's code of conduct. It is assumed that you have carefully reviewed the University's policy on plagiarism. Your use of AI must adhere to the university's policy. Please note that you are unlikely to succeed on the midterm and final exam if you have not studied the readings in detail and thought about them yourself. Likewise, you need to be able to display ownership over the ideas expressed in your book review in our one-on-one meeting to receive a high grade. This will be considerably easier if you have written the review yourself.

Accessibility: The University is committed to equal access for students with disabilities. Students with disabilities who have been approved to receive academic accommodations by the University must contact me as soon as possible so that the relevant accommodations can be made.

Week 1: Theoretical tools (2 lectures). Why does war arise if it is costly for both sides? How do states respond to challenges by other states?

Fearon, James. "Rationalist explanations for war." *International Organization* 49.3 (1995): 379-414.

Walt, Stephen. *The Origins of Alliances*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1987 (selections).

Week 2: Traditional explanations for the First World War (2 lectures). What are the merits and limitations of traditional explanations for the outbreak of war in 1914? To what extent does it make sense to blame German revisionism for the outbreak of war?

Tuchman, Barbara. *The Guns of August: The Outbreak of World War I*. New York: Random House, 1994 (selections).

Fischer, Fritz. *Germany's Aims in the First World War*. New York: Norton, 1968 (selections).

Anderson, Perry. "Fritz Fischer." In *Disputing Disaster: A Sextet on the Great War*. London: Verso, 2024.

Week 3: Alliance formation and the triple entente (2 lectures). What explains the French alliance with Russia? Was Britain's subsequent rapprochement with both countries motivated by balancing or bandwagoning? What were Russia's objectives?

Kennan, George. *The Fateful Alliance: France, Russia, and the Coming of the First World War*. New York: Pantheon, 1984 (selections).

Steiner, Zara, and Keith Wilson. *Britain and the Origins of the First World War*. 2nd ed. London: Palgrave, 2003 (selections).

McMeekin, Sean. *The Russian Origins of the First World War*. Cambridge, MA: Belknap, 2011 (selections).

Week 4: Power shifts and preventive war (2 lectures). How did the shifting balance of power in the years leading up to 1914 affect the prospects of war? Was the outbreak of war a result of preventive action by Austria against Serbia and/or by Germany against Russia?

Seligmann, Matthew. "The Anglo-German Naval Race, 1898–1914." In *Arms Races in International Politics: From the Nineteenth to the Twenty-First Century*, ed. Thomas Mahnken. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016.

Levy, Jack, and William Mulligan. "Shifting Power, Preventive Logic, and the Response of the Target: Germany, Russia, and the First World War." *Journal of Strategic Studies* 40.5 (2017): 731–769.

Clark, Christopher. *The Sleepwalkers: How Europe Went to War in 1914*. New York: Harper, 2014 (selections).

Week 5: Uncertainty and the outbreak of war (2 lectures). Was war a result of uncertainty about other states' capabilities or resolve to fight? Why was there uncertainty about Russia's resolve to intervene on behalf of Serbia and Britain's resolve to intervene on behalf of Belgium and France?

Sagan, Scott D. "1914 Revisited: Allies, Offense, and Instability." *International Security* 11.2 (1986): 151–175.

Ferguson, Niall. *The Pity of War: Explaining World War I*. New York: Basic Books, 1999 (selections).

Clark, Christopher. *The Sleepwalkers: How Europe Went to War in 1914*. New York: Harper, 2014 (selections).

Week 6: Why the war persisted (2 lectures). Why wasn't the war concluded through negotiation after the initial stalemate? In what ways did domestic politics stand in the way of successful negotiation?

von Clausewitz, Carl. *On War*. Trans. Peter Paret. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1989 (selections).

Stevenson, David. "The failure of peace by negotiation in 1917." *Historical Journal* 34.1 (1991): 65–86.

Afflerbach, Holger. *On a Knife Edge: How Germany Lost the First World War*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022 (selections).

Week 7: Peace and the conditions for future war (2 lectures). Did the 1919 Treaty of Versailles make future war inevitable? How did the territorial revisions and emergence of new states in Central Europe affect the prospects for future war?

Macmillan, Margaret. *Paris 1919: Six Months That Changed the World*. New York: Random House, 2003 (selections).

Steiner, Zara. *The lights that failed: European international history, 1919-1933*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005 (selections).

Böhler, Jochen. *Civil War in Central Europe, 1918-1921: The Reconstruction of Poland*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2019 (selections).

Week 8: German foreign policy objectives (2 lectures). What were the foreign policy goals of Germany's governments in the Weimar Republic? In what ways were Hitler's objectives similar? Was peaceful revisionism possible or could territorial change only be achieved through the threat of force?

Wright, Jonathan. "Foreign Policy: The Dilemmas of a Revisionist State." In *The Oxford Handbook of the Weimar Republic*, ed. N. Rossol and B. Ziemann, 242-263. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2020.

Fink, Carole. "Defender of minorities: Germany in the League of Nations, 1926-1933." *Central European History* 5.4 (1972): 330-357.

Taylor, A.J.P. *The Origins of the Second World War*. New York: Atheneum, 1983 (selections).

Week 9: Power shifts, preventive war, and Hitler's program (2 lectures). To what extent should we see the Second World War as arising from preventive motives? Did the growing power of the Soviet Union create preventive incentives for German expansion? Was Hitler's pursuit of empire in the east a means to balance against the British empire and the growing power of the United States?

Copeland, Dale. *The Origins of Major War*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2000 (selections).

Overy, Richard. *Blood and Ruins: The Last Imperial War, 1931-1945*. New York: Viking, 2022 (selections).

Koch, H.W. "Hitler's 'Programme' and the Genesis of Operation 'Barbarossa'." *Historical Journal* 26.4 (1983): 891-920.

Week 10: Constraints on internal and external balancing (2 lectures). Why did Britain and France choose appeasement over confrontation with Germany from 1935 to early 1939? How might this be explained by domestic political constraints, beliefs about the greater threat posed by the Soviet Union, and fears about mutual destruction via air war?

Trubowitz, Peter, and Peter Harris. "When states appease: British appeasement in the 1930s." *Review of International Studies* 41.2 (2015): 289-311.

Haslam, Jonathan. *The Spectre of War: International Communism and the Origins of World War II*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2021 (selections).

Bialer, Uri. *The Shadow of the Bomber: The Fear of Air Attack and British Politics, 1932–1939*. London: Royal Historical Society, 1980 (selections).

Week 11: From appeasement to ineffective deterrence (2 lectures). Why did Britain abandon appeasement and offer a guarantee to Poland? What was the lesson of Germany's occupation of Czechoslovakia in March 1939? Why did British and French efforts to secure Soviet support for the defense of Poland fail, and why did Stalin and Hitler conclude a non-aggression pact?

Bryant, Chad. *Prague in Black: Nazi Rule and Czech Nationalism*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2007 (selections).

Watt, Donald Cameron. *How War Came: The Immediate Origins of the Second World War*. New York: Pantheon, 1989 (selections).

McMeekin, Sean. *Stalin's War: A New History of World War II*. New York: Basic Books, 2021 (selections).

Week 12: Phony war and the shifting balance of power (2 lectures). Why didn't Britain and France undertake major offensive operations after declaring war on Germany? Was Germany's attack on France motivated by a preventive logic? Was France's defensive strategy misguided?

Imlay, Talbot Charles. "A Reassessment of Anglo-French Strategy during the Phony War, 1939-1940." *English Historical Review* 119.481 (2004): 333-372.

Passmore, Kevin. *The Maginot Line: A New History*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2025 (selections).

Tooze, Adam. *The Wages of Destruction: The Making and Breaking of the Nazi Economy*. London: Allen Lane, 2006 (selections).

Week 13: Barbarossa and genocide (2 lectures). Why did Germany attack the Soviet Union in 1941? How did genocide become a part of the German war program and how did the Holocaust relate to earlier instances of wartime mass murder in Central and Eastern Europe?

Kershaw, Ian. *Fateful Choices: Ten Decisions that Changed the World, 1940-1941*. New York: Penguin, 2007 (selections).

Bloxham, Donald. *The Final Solution: A Genocide*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009 (selections).

Browning, Christopher. "Problem Solvers." In *The Oxford Handbook of Holocaust Studies*, eds. P. Hayes and J. Roth, 128-141. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011.